

Soviet Tanks: 1941-45

A huge number of Soviet soldiers and tanks were lost in the first few months of the German invasion of the Soviet Union. Soviet tank factories were relocated east, beyond the Ural Mountains; until they were able to resume full operations, British and American tanks were also used. As the war progressed, production was standardized as much as possible in order to increase output. The tanks were accordingly simple, reflecting the limited skills of their crews, who were very often inexperienced or poorly trained.



Armor impervious to antitank guns



152 mm howitzer

Tall, heavy turret

Torsion bar suspension

△ **Kliment Voroshilov-1 (KV-1)**
Date 1939 **Country** Soviet Union
Weight 53.2 tons (48.3 tonnes)
Engine Kharkiv Model V-2K diesel, 500 hp
Main armament 76.2 mm ZIS-5 L/41.5 gun

A heavy tank, the KV-1 was virtually immune to the German antitank weapons of 1941. It was one of the few tanks to continue in production after the Soviet factories were relocated. It used the same engine and gun as the T-34, but, being heavier, had poorer mobility. Around 4,700 KV-1s were built before production halted in April 1943.

◁ **Kliment Voroshilov-2 (KV-2)**
Date 1939 **Country** Soviet Union
Weight 59.4 tons (53.9 tonnes)
Engine Kharkiv Model V-2K diesel, 550 hp
Main armament 152 mm M-10T L/20 howitzer

After facing well fortified Finnish bunkers during 1939-40, the Soviets were convinced that a tank armed with an artillery piece was vital—and the KV-2 was their initial response. It was a good concept, but it failed to work in practice: the KV-2's tall turret made the tank heavier, slower, and easier to target. Just 334 were built, production ending when the Germans invaded Russia in 1941.

▷ **T-34**
Date 1941 **Country** Soviet Union
Weight 34.6 tons (31.4 tonnes)
Engine Kharkiv Model V-2-34 diesel, 500 hp
Main armament 76.2 mm F-34 L/41 gun

One of the most important tanks in history, the T-34 began development as early as 1938. Wartime pressures precluded cosmetic considerations, the focus being more on reducing cost and accelerating production.



45 mm rear hull armor